

CHINEMELU OKAFOR

Harvard University Government Department
Cambridge, Massachusetts 02138

Email: cokafor@g.harvard.edu
Website: www.chinemeluokafor.com

Research Interests	Political economy; comparative politics; public economics; economic development; economic history; narrative economics; MSME development in emerging markets; international economics and trade	
Education	Harvard University	Cambridge, MA
	Ph.D. Government, <i>Karl Deutsch Fellow</i>	2027 (<i>expected</i>)
	<i>Committee:</i> Melani Cammett (chair), Mashail Malik, Nathan Nunn, Pia Raffler, Awa Ambra Seck	
	Princeton University	Princeton, NJ
	Emerging Scholars in Political Science Program	August 2021
	The George Washington University	Washington, DC
	M.A. Applied Economics, <i>Dean's Award</i>	May 2018
	The University of Michigan	Ann Arbor, MI
	B.A. Economics, B.A. International Studies	May 2015
Works in Progress	The Origins of Women's Economic and Political Participation in Africa [Abstract] Protest Matters: The Effects of Protests on Economic Redistribution, <i>Under Review</i> , [NBER WP] The Effects of Women-Led Protests on Gender Gaps in Political Participation [Abstract]	
Selected Teaching	Harvard: Spring '26 '25 - Business & Entrepreneurship in Africa (HBSMBA 1555), Hakeem Belo-Osagie Harvard: Fall '25 '24 - Public Economics (ECON 1410), Stan Veuger Harvard: Spring '25 - Evaluating the Impact of Public Policies (GOV 1737), Prof. Michael Hiscox	
Academic Affiliations	Harvard Center for International Development, PhD Affiliate	January 2025 - Present
	Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Graduate Associate	August 2024 - Present
	Harvard Institute for Quantitative Social Science, Graduate Affiliate	October 2022 - Present
	LBS Wheeler Institute's African Research Councillors Programme, Collaborator	May 2022 - Present
Selected Presentations	American Political Science Association Annual Meeting (<i>2026</i>)	
	PhD Excellence Initiative Conference, Stanford University (<i>2026</i>)	
	Harvard Center for African Studies Contested Realities Workshop (<i>2025</i>)	
	London Business School, Wheeler Institute - African History Through the Lens of Economics (<i>2022</i>)	
	J-PAL Research Staff Training, Massachusetts Institute of Technology (<i>2020, 2022</i>)	
Professional Distinctions	Econometric Society Africa Summer School (AFSS)	June 2026
	Association for Comparative Economic Studies (ACES) Summer School	July 2025
	American Political Science Association Member Spotlight	July 2025
	Harvard Department of Government Karl Deutsch Fellowship	August 2021
	Harvard Graduate School of Arts and Sciences Graduate Prize Fellowship	August 2021
	American Political Science Association Diversity Fellowship	December 2020
Selected Awards	Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Dissertation Writing Fellowship	August 2026
	Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Pre (<i>x2</i>) & Mid-dissertation Grant	April 2026
	John C. Hansen & Katherine Vogelheim, Research Grant	January 2026
	Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, GSA Grant (<i>x2</i>)	October 2025
	Harvard Center for African Studies, Travel Grant	May 2025

	Harvard Government Department, Women and Politics Research Grant	April 2025
	Harvard Jens Aubrey Westengard Scholarship	May 2024
	Forbes 30 Under 30 N. America: Education - Founder, Research in Color Foundation	November 2022
	Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Summer Language Grant	April 2022
	Best Overall Performance in the Applied Economics Master's Program, <i>Dean's Award</i>	May 2018
Professional Service	Reviewer for: <i>The Annual Review of Economics</i>	
	Harvard Concentration Advisor, Thesis Advisor and Non-Resident Tutor	August 2024 - Present
	Harvard Resident Tutor, <i>Winthrop House</i>	August 2021 - August 2023
	Specialities: French Language, Public Service, First-gen Low-income, Economics, and Government	
	The Research In Color Foundation	May 2019 - Present
	<u>Founder and President</u>	
	Founded and lead <u>Research In Color</u> a 501(c)(3) non-profit which seeks to increase the number and improve retention of historically excluded scholars in economics and economics-adjacent disciplines.	
Research Experience	White House Council of Economic Advisers (<i>took leave from PhD</i>)	Washington, DC
	Staff Economist	August 2023 - August 2024
	Advisors: Dr. Sandile Hlatshwayo	
	Area(s) of focus: International Economics & Trade; AGOA; China Shock; Section 201 & 301 Tariffs	
	Selected Projects: Economic Report of the President, Chapter 4, <i>Council of Economic Advisers</i> 2024	
	Emerging Scholars in Political Science Program	Princeton, NJ
	Predoctoral Research Specialist	August 2019 - August 2021
	Advisors: Prof. Leonard Wantchekon	
	Area(s) of focus: Historical applied microeconomics	
	Digitized historical maps of Nigeria in QGIS to support ongoing research on the long-run effects of colonial missionary education on present-day living standards, occupation, and political participation	
	Empirical Studies of Conflict Project	Princeton, NJ
	Research Specialist II	September 2018 - August 2019
	Advisors: Prof. Tarek Ghani and Prof. Jake Shapiro	
	Areas of focus: Natural resource extraction and conflict in Sub-Saharan Africa	
	Preprocessed spatial data and created interactive map of Africa by merging firm-level ownership identifiers of extractive sites in oil, gas, and mining, to instances of violent conflict	
	Selected Projects: Mining Competition and Violent Conflict in Africa, <i>Journal of Politics</i> 2025	
	The International Finance Corporation (IFC)	Washington, DC
	Research Assistant	February - October 2018
	Advisors: Dr. Tristan Reed and Dr. Alexandros Ragoussis	
	Area(s) of focus: Private sector firm development in Sub-Saharan Africa	
	Created indicators of infrastructure access and ran synthetic panel fixed effects regressions to measure inclusiveness and equality of markets to electric power and water for households	
	Selected Projects: Making It Big: Why Developing Countries Need More Large Firms, <i>IFC</i> 2020;	
	Creating Impact: The Promise of Impact Investing, <i>IFC</i> 2019;	
	Beyond Capital: Monitoring Development Outcomes of Multinational Enterprises, <i>World Bank</i> 2018	
	The World Bank	Washington, DC
	Consultant	June - August 2017
	Advisors: Kinley Salmon and Nabila Assaf	
	Area(s) of focus: Major challenges to firm operations in post-conflict settings	
	Selected Projects: Surviving Firms of the Syrian Arab Republic, <i>World Bank</i> 2018	
Skills	RStudio, R Shiny, STATA, L ^A T _E X, ArcGIS, Qualtrics, JavaScript, Microsoft Office Suite	
Languages	English (Native proficiency), French (Upper-intermediate proficiency), Igbo (Passive proficiency)	